Since World War II ended in 1945, there has not been a single day of global peace. At all times fighting has been going on somewhere in the world. Military theoreticians have repeatedly predicted the demise of the traditional fighting man, rendered obsolete by nuclear weaponry or by precision-guided munitions delivered from a safe distance. Yet even the most sophisticated armies with advanced electronic equipment, guided missiles, and remote-controlled aircraft have repeatedly found themselves forced to engage in face-to-face combat, whether in the streets of Iraqi cities or the jungle of Vietnam.

COLD WAR

The context for the first four decades of the postwar era was the global confrontation between two nuclear-armed superpowers, the United States and the Soviet Union. They avoided direct conflict through fear of the destructive power of each other's weaponry, but contested limited regional wars, either sending in their forces or supporting the armies of smaller powers. The largest of these wars was in Korea from 1950 to 1953 – where the US and its allies intervened under the United Nations banner in support of South Korea against Soviet- and Chinese-backed North Korea – and in Vietnam from the mid-1960s. Those US formations that established an outstanding reputation in World War II, including the Marine Corps and Airborne divisions, were again called on to bear the worst of the fighting.

People's Liberation Army
Known as the Red Army up until 1946, China's PLA is the largest standing army in the world with 1.6 million active ground troops. In theory, all citizens have to serve in the PLA, but in practice, military service is voluntary.







